

Chapter 78-1

Liang Xinhe had long known that she had started acting, but he didn't expect her progress to be this fast. When he heard that she would be joining the production next week as the third female lead, he was quite surprised.

"Is it that surprising?" Liang Shi smiled lightly. "I'm very talented when it comes to acting."

"It is quite surprising." Liang Xinhe looked at her while casually opening her resignation letter. It was the typical, run-of-the-mill resignation template, but it was handwritten, and the handwriting was beautiful. Especially the artistic signature at the bottom—one could tell at a glance that she had practiced it.

Liang Xinhe was amazed. "When did you practice your handwriting?"

"When I had nothing better to do," Liang Shi said. "My original handwriting was too ugly."

Liang Xinhe responded absent-mindedly, hesitating several times as if wanting to say something but holding back.

Liang Shi roughly knew what he wanted to say, but she didn't bring up the topic. Instead, she directly changed the subject. "Remember to watch when my drama airs."

"Of course." Liang Xinhe's fingers fidgeted with the bottom right corner of her resignation letter. After a pause, he said, "Do you really have to resign? Can't you just come back to work when you're not filming? Or I could give you a nominal position."

"Just like before?" Liang Shi smiled. "Let's not. That would be giving me special treatment again."

"What's wrong with special treatment? You're the Third Miss of the Liang family. Who would dare say anything about you?" Liang Xinhe said. "It's just a nominal position. Your salary would be deposited into your account every month as usual, and you wouldn't need to come to work. If you feel like it, you can drop by anytime—think of it as going shopping."

"Who comes to a company to go shopping?" Liang Shi said. "Let's just forget it. When I'm resting, I can go watch a movie or go to the mall."

"But you..." Liang Xinhe frowned. "How about we ask Big Brother?"

"You were the one who brought me here in the first place. Now I want to leave and I have to ask Big Brother?" Liang Shi sat across from him and urged, "Hurry up, stop dawdling."

Liang Xinhe stared at the resignation letter. After some hesitation, he still said, "We still need to ask Big Brother. I can't make this decision."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Asking Big Brother will get the same result," Liang Shi said. "Don't break the rules just for me. I came to work because I could, and now I need to go do other things. It's not good for me to take up a position."

But Liang Xinhe didn't listen to her. He took out his phone to call Liang Xinzhou, but before he could even dial, the office door was pushed open.

Liang Xinzhou walked in with a gloomy expression. Without even looking to see who was there, he closed the office door and demanded, "Did you send people to dig up dirt on Zuoye Culture?"

"Yes," Liang Xinhe said, while giving him a meaningful look.

Liang Xinzhou also noticed Liang Shi sitting there, and his anger suddenly dissipated.

But his expression was still not good.

"Big Brother." Liang Shi greeted him, then stood up and said, "I'll leave first."

They were probably going to discuss matters concerning the Liang family's real heiress, so she should hurry and leave.

She didn't want to get involved.

Liang Shi felt that as the fake heiress, the best thing she could do was to distance herself from this family.

That way, none of the problems between them would affect her.

As for settling scores with Qiu Zimin, that could wait until later.

A gentleman's revenge is never too late, even after ten years.¹

The premise being that it wouldn't implicate those who had been good to her.

But unexpectedly, just as she stood up, Liang Xinhe pressed her shoulders and made her sit back down. "You're also a member of this family. Listen together."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I just came to submit my resignation letter," Liang Shi made one final attempt to struggle free. "Now that I've submitted it, you two can discuss."

"Resignation letter?" Liang Xinzhou was surprised. "Where are you going?"

"To act," Liang Shi explained. "Didn't you all know about this before?"

Liang Xinzhou was silent for a moment, then signed her resignation letter. "Alright, do well with your acting."

Then he asked, "Do you have a talent agency? Dongheng has a subsidiary agency with some quite popular artists. How about signing with them? I'll have them assign you a good agent."

Liang Shi immediately shook her head. "No need. I can manage on my own."

"The entertainment industry is chaotic. Going it alone isn't ideal, is it? You need someone to take care of you while filming, and after filming, you need someone to coordinate with the production crew and such—don't you need people for all that? Do you have an assistant and an agent?" After Liang Xinzhou finished asking in a steady tone, he didn't wait for her answer and wanted to arrange things for her. "Then I'll just have Haicheng Culture assign you a good agent. No contract needed, so you can move freely, and they can also connect you with resources."

"Really, there's no need." Liang Shi held down his hand that was about to make the call. "I really can manage on my own."

Afraid that Liang Xinzhou wouldn't believe her, she deliberately emphasized the word "really." Pronouncing it with particular clarity and sincerity.

Liang Xinzhou looked at her with uncertainty and said in a deep voice, "This is a one-time offer. If you regret it later and come begging me, it won't work."

"I know," Liang Shi said. "But I really don't need it. I can handle everything myself."

"Indeed." Liang Xinhe, who had been listening silently on the side, chimed in. "When Ah Shi handled that PR crisis before, she was even better than that old guy at our company."

"That was just a coincidence," Liang Shi said. "But I can protect myself."

Liang Xinzhou was silent for a moment, then finally agreed. "Alright then, let me know if you need anything in the future."

"Great, thank you, Big Brother." Liang Shi finally let out a sigh of relief.

After saying that, she tried to leave again, but Liang Xinzhou pressed her down. "Just stay and listen."

Liang Shi: "..."

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1. A Chinese proverb meaning that a patient person can wait a long time to exact revenge. It emphasizes the value of patience and strategic timing in seeking justice or retribution.

Chapter 78-2

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As it turned out, three days ago, the people Father Liang had sent to search for their daughter had found a lead, and it happened to match with the girl searching for her family online.

If she had been in a state of no contact, they might not have found her this quickly.

But Guo Xinran had stirred up quite a commotion online. If the Liang family members had bothered to look at those "useless" social media platforms, they might have seen it much earlier.

After learning Guo Xinran's specific address, the Liang parents drove early in the morning to that remote place.

It took over nine hours to drive there from Haizhou City, so by the time they met her, it was already approaching evening. Apparently, when they arrived, Guo Xinran was rolling up her sleeves to slaughter a chicken.

The place where she lived was shabby and run-down. The ground was muddy from the recent rain, and the Liang couple's eyes welled up with tears just looking at it.

Looking at that face that bore such a striking resemblance to Qiu Zimin's when she was young, they could almost certainly conclude that this was their daughter who had been lost for twenty-five years.

But to be safe, they still took Guo Xinran to the provincial capital hospital for a DNA test.

With today's advanced technology, the test results could come out in just two hours.

So Qiu Zimin shared this news with everyone in the group chat. None of the people waiting for news at the Liang family's old residence had a happy expression on their faces.

Even the usually kind and generous Sun Meirou couldn't find words to comfort everyone.

That very day, Liang Xinzhou had intended to pack up and move out, but Liang Xinhe persuaded him not to upset their parents too much. He said they should wait until their parents brought her back, take a look at their biological sister first, and then make a decision—after all, there were blood ties involved.

Liang Wanwan had also returned from school. She had always been quiet and reserved, and that day she joined Liang Xinhe in persuading him. In the end, Liang Xinzhou didn't manage to move out.

However, they were also in a state of quietly waiting for news.

Guo Xinran still had matters to handle over there, so it would be another two days before she could return.

Father Liang had dropped all the company's affairs and gone straight to the small village thousands of miles away.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe had no choice but to help with the aftermath.

The first thing that needed to be dealt with was that Guo Xinran had signed with Zuoye Culture. The contract had just been signed, requiring her to livestream her mountain village life.

But now that Guo Xinran had successfully reunited with her biological family, she naturally wouldn't stay in that small mountain village anymore. However, the person in charge on the other side was unwilling to let her go. When Father Liang learned of this matter, he wanted Guo Xinran to terminate her contract with Zuoye Culture.

The person at Zuoye Culture responsible for this matter had just returned from that godforsaken place in the middle of nowhere¹. When he learned about this, he was furious and threatened over the phone to take Guo Xinran to court.

How could the Liang couple, eager to protect their daughter, allow him to say such things?

So Father Liang said harshly, "Go ahead and sue. I'd like to see just how capable you are."

Zuoye Culture had no idea that Guo Xinran's biological parents were the renowned president of Dongheng Group, and directly contacted their lawyers.

Meanwhile, Father Liang called Liang Xinhe from thousands of miles away, telling him to make sure this matter was handled properly.

Liang Xinhe was also at a loss, but upon hearing that the other party had already sent a lawyer's letter, he could only agree under the pressure from his parents.

He had looked into Zuoye Culture—it was just an unknown livestreaming company with a registered capital of only one million yuan. The CEO was an internet celebrity who had made their fortune through livestream e-commerce. It wasn't any big company.

Normally, the way Liang Xinhe and his family would handle this would be to simply acquire the company.

But Liang Xinhe was unwilling to acquire it. The entertainment industry was notoriously difficult to manage, and their family already had Haicheng Culture, which was developing steadily. They didn't need an extra company.

The best method would be to pay ten million yuan in breach-of-contract penalties and be done with it.

Liang Xinhe was also unwilling to do that.

This sister hadn't even come back yet, and they were already supposed to fork out ten million yuan. No matter how you looked at it, something seemed fishy.

So he chose a more troublesome method that didn't require spending money or using their people.

But just as he started working on it, Liang Xinzhou found out.

Liang Xinhe looked confused. "Can't I help?"

Liang Xinzhou said in a deep voice, "You can, but we should wait until we've met her first. Besides, if you make such a big fuss about it, wouldn't that let everyone know we're helping an internet celebrity?"

"Internet celebrity?" Liang Xinhe was stunned. "She..."

"Someone who rose to fame through online livestreaming and continues to live in that kind of place putting on a show even after having the financial means to leave." Liang Xinzhou sneered. "If she's not an internet celebrity, then what is she?"

"But still..." Liang Xinhe wavered a bit, stammering, "You don't have to put it that way."

"She currently has a hundred thousand followers on Weibo and has done product promotions." Liang Xinzhou placed the tablet in his hands in front of him. "She has seven hundred thousand followers on the Yumao livestreaming platform. Many of her videos have over a hundred thousand likes, and her monthly income is at least thirty thousand yuan."

He laid out the real data one by one. "And she's only been doing this for less than half a year. Without someone pushing her from behind the scenes, how could she have accumulated so many followers in such a short time?"

Liang Xinhe froze, pursed his lips, and sighed. "I forgot about that."

"Instead of digging up dirt on artists under Zuoye Culture, you might as well investigate whether she's secretly colluding with people from Zuoye Culture." Liang Xinzhou said, "This looks a lot like a 'pig-butcher' scam."²

Liang Xinhe: "?"

"Pig-butcher scam?" Liang Xinhe was shocked. "What do you mean?"

"It's when two or more parties join forces to commit fraud," Liang Xinzhou said.

"No way?" Liang Xinhe was still somewhat incredulous. "She's just a farm girl who grew up in the countryside. Besides, she didn't even know our family was this wealthy, and that we would happen to reunite with her at this particular time."

"So isn't it possible that she originally didn't plan to scam us, but we just happened to walk right into it?" Liang Xinzhou adjusted his glasses, and suddenly winced, sucking in a sharp breath from the pain.

Only then did Liang Shi notice that there was a red scab on the lower part of his right eyelid.

It looked like a fresh scratch.

1. The original Chinese expression "雞不拉屎鳥不生蛋" literally means "a place where chickens don't defecate and birds don't lay eggs"—a colorful way to describe an extremely remote and desolate location. ⇐
2. "Pig-butcherer scam" (殺豬盤) is a type of fraud where scammers build trust with their victims over time (like "fattening a pig") before executing the scam (the "butcherer"). In this context, Liang Xinzhou suspects that Guo Xinran and Zuoye Culture might be working together in a coordinated scheme to defraud the Liang family. ⇐

Chapter 78-3

"What happened here?" Liang Shi asked.

"Mom—" Liang Xinhe was about to say, but was sharply interrupted by Liang Xinzhou. "Liang Xinhe."

Liang Xinhe sheepishly closed his mouth.

Liang Xinzhou explained, "I accidentally scratched myself."

But Liang Shi had heard what Liang Xinhe said. She looked at Liang Xinzhou and said helplessly, "You'd have to be pretty careless to scratch yourself there."

As she spoke, she stood up. "You two chat first. I'll be back in a bit."

After she left, Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe finally began discussing the situation they would face tonight.

Without a doubt, when the Liang parents brought back the long-lost biological sister, the whole family would feel awkward.

Awkwardness was secondary—the main issue was not knowing how to arrange things afterward.

As children, they really had no way to stop their parents from doing what they were determined to do.

However, Liang Xinhe first brought up the earlier matter. "Big Brother, I think you're overthinking this. How capable can someone from the countryside be? Can she really stir up that much trouble? You're being too paranoid."

"Then you should think about it more carefully." Liang Xinzhou put away his tablet. "How can someone from the countryside build up a self-media presence in less than half a year, and do it so successfully at that? She's clearly skilled at manipulating public opinion. Mom and Dad are blinded by their 'biological daughter' filter right now—are you blinded too?"

"No," Liang Xinhe denied. "I'm just trying to find a middle ground, aren't I? Otherwise, before our biological sister even comes back, this family will already be torn apart."

"There's no middle ground to be found." Liang Xinzhou sighed. "When you saw Mom arguing with Liang Shi, you should have known that there's no middle ground in this matter."

There was no option to have both.

It would only create rifts with both.

"But that biological sister is also quite pitiful," Liang Xinhe said. "She has no relatives left over there. Did you see what she wrote on Weibo? First her mother died, then her father died. She was raised by her grandmother all along, and it wasn't until her grandmother was on her deathbed that she was told she wasn't biological."

By the end, Liang Xinhe's tone carried a note of sorrow. "She's also always been called a jinx and a harbinger of death.¹ She's this old and no one dares to pursue her. Fate is truly cruel."

"So what?" Liang Xinzhou asked.

Liang Xinhe was stunned and looked at Liang Xinzhou with some shock. "Big Brother, aren't you being too cold? You can't even spare her a bit of pity? She's still our biological sis—"

Liang Xinzhou's stern gaze fixed firmly on Liang Xinhe, causing Liang Xinhe's voice to grow lower and lower until he couldn't continue.

Liang Xinzhou shook his head. "She's very pitiful, but... I'm skeptical about it."

"What do you mean?" Liang Xinhe asked. "These things can't all be made up, can they? If they were, someone from her village would surely come out and refute her. This kind of thing can be easily verified."

"I'm not saying she made it up," Liang Xinzhou said. "But there's definitely some exaggeration. Just based on that pinned Weibo post of hers, I'm skeptical. The word choice and sentence structure don't look like something written by someone who never went to college."

Liang Xinhe: "..."

"Can't she just be good at Chinese?" Liang Xinhe said sheepishly.

Liang Xinzhou stared at him, utterly speechless.

A few seconds later, he said with exasperation, "Read her Weibo post a few more times and you'll understand."

Liang Xinhe touched the tip of his nose, too embarrassed to say anything more.

Liang Shi only raised her hand to knock on the door after the argument between the two had subsided. She had gone downstairs to get iodine and band-aids. After entering, she handed them to Liang Xinzhou, but Liang Xinzhou waved his hand. "It's just a small wound. No need."

"Even a small wound is still on your face," Liang Shi said. "How could you be so careless? It won't be good if it leaves a scar later."

Liang Xinzhou stubbornly refused to let her treat it, but Liang Shi said helplessly, "Just listen to me this once."

Liang Xinzhou: "..."

Liang Shi disinfected the wound near his nose bridge, then used office scissors to cut the band-aid into small pieces and stuck them on, trying her best to make it less noticeable that there was a band-aid there.

After throwing all the scraps into the trash bin, she asked, "Where are you two headed?"

"Home," the two said in unison.

Liang Shi nodded. "Alright then, I'm going home too. Be careful on the road."

She didn't ask a single thing about the real heiress.

Before leaving, Liang Shi also said to Liang Xinhe, "Oh right, Second Brother, I'll still come to work tomorrow, but I won't be coming starting next week."

Liang Xinhe nodded. "Got it."

The two brothers watched Liang Shi's departing figure.

Liang Xinhe sighed with emotion. "Liang Shi has really changed."

"Growing up happens in an instant," Liang Xinzhou said. "Her rebellious phase is over, so naturally she's better now. Don't you think she's a lot like how she was as a child?"

Liang Xinhe: "...Is she?"

Liang Xinzhou nodded. "You spent less time with her, so you didn't notice."

"By the way, what did you say in the study last time about what Mom did to Liang Shi?" Liang Xinhe suddenly said. "Wasn't Liang Shi always the one Mom spoiled the most? I was never as favored as Ah Shi in front of her."

"Excessive indulgence," Liang Xinzhou said in a low voice. "Indulgence without boundaries. And Mom once gave Liang Shi to Qin Lishuang."

"Qin Lishuang?" Liang Xinhe frowned. "That painter who likes to do body art? She's the youngest daughter of the Qin family, right? Over forty and still unmarried."

"Yes." Liang Xinzhou let out a soft breath. "After I found out, I went to bring Liang Shi out, but Liang Shi had already spent one night with her... When I asked what happened, she wouldn't say."

"What the hell." Liang Xinhe was agitated. "What kind of messed up situation is this? Why would Mom give Liang Shi to her? Our family isn't at the point where we need to ask favors from people."

"It wasn't about asking for favors," Liang Xinzhou explained. "Mom said she didn't know. Qin Lishuang only told her she wanted to borrow Liang Shi as a model. She thought it would be culturally enriching and good for Liang Shi, so she let her guard down. To be precise, she didn't 'give' her away—she just let Liang Shi help as a model. But given Qin Lishuang's character..."

Liang Xinzhou's voice grew heavy. "I don't find that believable."

"Of course it's not believable," Liang Xinhe lowered his voice. "A friend of mine had a younger sister who was taken away by Qin Lishuang under the pretense of modeling, and she ended up... ruined."

"What?"

"She..." Liang Xinhe paused, then said in a muffled voice, "The kind where she can never have children again."

"Fuck." Even someone as composed as Liang Xinzhou couldn't help but let out a curse.

He still remembered the scene when he went to find Liang Shi, barging into Qin Lishuang's villa with people.

Rumors in the outside world said that Qin Lishuang was a crazy artist who would sleep with many people to find inspiration, and would also observe many people's bodies. Qin Lishuang would pay handsomely for it. Because the Qin family was considered a prestigious family in Haizhou City, and they also had marriage ties with the Lu family, a prominent family in the capital, no one said anything. Many things were just passed around within their circles.

People would just chat about it as idle gossip over tea.

When he found Liang Shi, she was wearing a black leather jacket, her hair tied up in a ponytail, wearing heavy makeup, with a terrible expression on her face.

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1. "掃把星" (sàobǎ xīng, literally "broom star") and "喪門星" (sāngmén xīng, literally "funeral door star") are Chinese superstitious terms for someone believed to bring bad luck or misfortune to those around them. These are deeply hurtful labels in Chinese culture, suggesting that the person's presence causes death or disaster. ↩

Chapter 78-4

Qin Lishuang smiled and said, "She's just a kid. What could I possibly do to her?"

Liang Xinzhou said, "Don't touch my sister again in the future."

Qin Lishuang flirtatiously reached out to lift Liang Shi's chin, but Liang Shi flung her hand away. "Don't touch me."

Qin Lishuang laughed. "This kid has quite a temper."

Liang Xinzhou took Liang Shi out. When he asked her what had happened, Liang Shi wouldn't say.

Later, when they got home, Liang Xinzhou had a huge argument with Qiu Zimin. The fight back then was even more intense than the current one over finding the real heiress.

However, Liang Xinzhou was still young at the time and hadn't started his own family yet. When arguing with Qiu Zimin, he wasn't as firm as he was now, but rather came across as willful.

Faced with his harsh accusations, Qiu Zimin patiently explained herself.

After observing for a while longer and finding that Qiu Zimin might truly not have known about Qin Lishuang's character, he finally let the matter drop at home.

Liang Xinhe had always been carefree and didn't concern himself much with such matters, so naturally he hadn't noticed any of this.

From beginning to end, Liang Xinzhou never found out what happened during that night Liang Shi spent at Qin Lishuang's place. Liang Shi wouldn't say, and asking Qin Lishuang was out of the question.

However, Liang Xinzhou had always felt that Liang Shi's rebellious phase lasting so many years must have something to do with Qiu Zimin.

It was Qiu Zimin's indulgence without boundaries that caused Liang Shi to develop such a personality.

That incident had always been like a thorn lodged in Liang Xinzhou's heart, pricking him from time to time.

Even if it was Qiu Zimin's mistake, it was Liang Shi who bore the consequences.

He had tried his best to be strict with Liang Shi, but Liang Shi didn't appreciate it, so he could only let her be.

As long as Liang Shi was safe and sound, that was enough. The family never expected her to achieve anything anyway.

Now that she had found something she liked to do, it couldn't be better.

"What about Mom saying she's going to sell the villa..." Liang Xinhe suddenly asked.

Liang Xinzhou frowned. "She's probably just saying that. How can such a big villa be sold just like that? Even if she really wants to sell it, it can't be sold in a short time. Let's get through tonight first. I have properties elsewhere. If it doesn't work out, I'll have the two of them move there."

"Alright." Liang Xinhe let out a sigh of relief, but at the same time felt like something was weighing on his heart, making him unable to calm down. So he made small talk to fill the silence. "Is Sister-in-law pregnant? I've noticed she's been particularly sleepy lately."

"Mm." Liang Xinzhou didn't hide it. "We found out last week. It's only been a little over a month. We originally planned to announce it this Monday, but..."

Their parents had run off without a trace. Who was there to tell?

Liang Xinhe patted his shoulder. "Let's see how things go first. If she's too spoiled and arrogant, then you guys should move out. I'll support you."

Yu Wan had been overworked in previous years and her health had deteriorated significantly. She had taken a lot of medication before finally getting pregnant—protecting the pregnancy was definitely the priority.

If anything went wrong now, his big brother would go crazy.

Liang Xinzhou glanced at him. "You should be the one to watch out."

Liang Xinhe: "?"

"She's definitely not the spoiled and arrogant type," Liang Xinzhou said coldly. "But she should be very good at playing the victim.¹ You've been soft-hearted since you were little, so don't fall for her tricks. Also, your wife—since she never grew up around us, it's like having a stranger enter the family. It's never wrong to stay vigilant."

Liang Xinhe still felt he was being overly tense, and muttered to him, "She's just a little girl from the countryside. What kind of waves could she possibly make?"

"You've been in the workplace for so long—haven't you learned yet?" Liang Xinzhou lectured him. "The ones you need to watch out for the most are those who play dumb to catch you off guard."²

Liang Xinhe: "..."

Anyway, following behind his big brother meant he was always going to get lectured.

1. "苦肉計" (kǔròu jì) literally means "self-inflicted injury scheme." It's one of the famous Thirty-Six Stratagems in Chinese military and political strategy, referring to the tactic of deliberately harming oneself or appearing pitiful to gain sympathy and lower the enemy's guard. ⇐
2. "扮豬吃老虎" (bàn zhū chī lǎohǔ) literally means "pretend to be a pig to eat the tiger." It's a Chinese idiom describing someone who deliberately appears weak, foolish, or harmless in order to deceive others and gain an advantage. ⇐

Chapter 78-5

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When Liang Shi returned home, Xu Qingzhu hadn't come back yet.

She had to meet with Su Zhe today to discuss some matters, and had given advance notice that she would be back late.

When Liang Shi got back, there were several uninvited guests standing in her living room.

She was completely bewildered. She glanced at the entrance and confirmed that they hadn't snuck in by picking the lock, but had openly entered by pressing the code on the door lock.

The housekeeper was also accompanying them.

The previous housekeeper and servants had all been assigned by Qiu Zimin. After Liang Shi had openly argued with Qiu Zimin, Qiu Zimin had withdrawn all the staff from her place.

Liang Shi would hire people online every week to clean the house. Normally, it was just her and Xu Qingzhu, and they didn't generate much trash, so they did it themselves.

But now, this housekeeper had reappeared, bringing along several strangers who had the demeanor of tourists on a sightseeing trip.

Those strangers were also startled when they saw her, and immediately asked the housekeeper, "Who is this?"

"Who are you?" Liang Shi asked. "Why did you barge in without permission?"

The housekeeper bowed to her. "Third Miss, these are prospective buyers here to view the property."

Liang Shi: "?"

OK, Qiu Zimin moved fast.

She had thought she was moving quickly, but she didn't expect Qiu Zimin to move even faster.

And suddenly she felt her intuition had been spot on—she had been feeling like she should move for a while now. Who would have thought...

Then she watched as this group of people sat in her living room signing a contract, demanding that she move out before next Monday.

Liang Shi stood there listening to them negotiate the price, then discuss which furniture would be left behind, completely ignoring the person who actually lived there.

Though Liang Shi didn't feel she had any say in the matter either.

Yes, without money, you have no say.

The property rights of this house were under Qiu Zimin's name. Although this was the marital home bought for Liang Shi, it had been registered under Qiu Zimin's name at the time of purchase, given to her only in Qiu Zimin's name.

Now even if she wanted to sue, she couldn't, because she couldn't prove it was a gift.

There was no written documentation.

In the end, the deal was closed at thirteen million yuan.

Because the buyers also wanted to renovate after Liang Shi and her wife moved out, they wanted them to move out as soon as possible.

After the negotiation was finished, the housekeeper put on a fake sympathetic expression and said to Liang Shi, "Third Miss, I'm truly sorry. When I came, I saw that neither you nor your wife were home, so I took the liberty of opening the door. We couldn't keep the buyers waiting."

Liang Shi smiled. "Alright."

"As you've heard," the housekeeper said, "the buyers will be moving in before next Monday. It would be best if you and your wife move out of the villa soon. I'll bring people over on Sunday for a cleaning. If any of your belongings are still here by then, I'll have them all disposed of as trash. Please understand."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Leave," Liang Shi's patience was about to run out. "Before I completely lose my temper."

The housekeeper left with the group.

After the villa quieted down, Liang Shi still stood at the entrance.

Having had a bunch of strangers suddenly barge into her home, after experiencing such an intrusion, her mild germaphobia made it impossible for her to go in and stay there right away.

After breathing enough fresh air outside, she finally closed the door and went inside, but headed straight to her room.

Those people had just sat on her sofa!

This was unbearable!

Liang Shi had already gotten the password to Zhao Xuning's place earlier and had registered her face for the facial recognition. Both unlocking methods were set up, so she could move anytime.

She went straight to her room, took out her suitcase, opened all the cabinets and drawers, and quickly packed up her belongings.

She didn't have many things here to begin with. The original owner's clothes were all flashy and gaudy, and she had donated them long ago. Most of what she had were everyday clothes she had bought herself, plus a few formal gowns for important occasions. The most numerous were her work clothes and a few sets of pajamas.

After finishing packing, she sat on the carpet and sent a message to Xu Qingzhu: [Teacher Xu, we need to move earlier than planned.]

They had originally agreed to move on Saturday, and there was actually still time, but Liang Shi couldn't stay in a place where she felt so insecure.

She kept feeling like someone could come in at any moment.

So she decided to move tomorrow.

Chapter 78-6

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When Xu Qingzhu saw this message, she had just arrived at the door of the restaurant's private room. The waiter led her inside, and the room was empty.

She casually picked a seat and sat down, then replied: [What happened?]

Liang Shi replied instantly: [The house has been sold. A bunch of people just came into the house. I'm about to explode.]

An expression like "about to explode" rarely appeared when it came to Liang Shi, which showed just how angry she was.

Xu Qingzhu comforted her: [Then I'll go back tonight to pack up, and we'll move tomorrow.]

Liang Shi: [That's what I was thinking too. If you come back early, we can move tonight.]

A few seconds later, she sent another message: [Actually, forget it. Let's stay at a hotel tonight.]

Xu Qingzhu: [...]

Liang Shi: [Is that not okay?]

Xu Qingzhu: [It's fine. Then you book the hotel.]

Liang Shi: [Okay.]

Xu Qingzhu gave Liang Shi the utmost tolerance.

She didn't ask why, nor did she criticize.

After all, Liang Shi's behavior would seem somewhat neurotic to anyone. Moving wasn't an urgent matter, and they clearly had a house to stay in, yet she insisted on dragging someone to stay at a hotel.

But Xu Qingzhu simply answered that it was fine.

For Liang Shi, this kind of situation was indeed infuriating. It inexplicably made one feel like their personal space had been invaded.

It fell into the category of things she couldn't tolerate.

Liang Shi quickly booked a hotel—a suite.

After seeing it, Xu Qingzhu lowered her eyelids and replied expressionlessly: [This room is quite expensive.]

Liang Shi: [...I can't exactly have you stay somewhere of poor quality.]

One suite for two thousand yuan a night.

Liang Shi was really going all out.

Xu Qingzhu had thought she would book two adjacent rooms, or a twin room.

She was in the middle of replying to the message when the door to the private room was pushed open. She casually sent a reply: [Got it.]

Then she looked up at the arrivals.

It wasn't just Su Zhe—Su Zhe's wife Meng Tong was also there. She was someone with an artistic temperament and looked very gentle.

Xu Qingzhu stood up and nodded to the two of them. "President Su, Mrs. Su, hello."

Since she still didn't know what to call them, she used distant and detached forms of address.

Su Zhe's expression wasn't good. After sitting down, he got straight to the point. "I thought you would need a few more days to think about it. I didn't expect you to decide so quickly."

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu smiled. "Did you not sleep well last night?"

Su Zhe took a sip of tea and changed the subject. "Just tell me about your matter. Tell me the result of your deliberation."

"Do I really have to choose one or the other?" Xu Qingzhu said neither humbly nor arrogantly. "I'm rather greedy. I want everything."

"Impossible!" Su Zhe said angrily. "I told you so much, not to get this result from you! How can you possibly have everything?"

"Everyone else has both a father and a mother. Why can't I?" Xu Qingzhu asked back lightly.

Su Zhe: "..."

This one sentence left Su Zhe at a loss for words. He was stunned for a long time before answering, "Can your situation be the same as everyone else's? Your father has passed away now. All that's left is your mother."

"But my mother doesn't even remember me," Xu Qingzhu said. "So if I say I want to acknowledge her now, will she suddenly remember me?"

Su Zhe: "..."

The private room fell silent for a long time. Su Zhe sighed helplessly. "She remembers now."

This time it was Xu Qingzhu's turn to be stunned. Clearly, that day she still didn't know anything.

But when she saw her, she would inexplicably shed tears, would subconsciously answer her questions, and would ask if they had met somewhere before.

Xu Qingzhu frowned. "What do you mean?"

Su Zhe opened his mouth, not knowing how to explain it to her. It was Meng Tong who spoke from the side, "Last night your mother had another dream. After crying herself awake in the middle of the night, she asked us, 'Where is my daughter?'"

Meng Tong said in a deep voice, "She doesn't even recognize Sheng Yu anymore, but she remembered what happened over twenty years ago."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

For two nights in a row, the Su household had been in turmoil because of Su Yao. No one could get a good night's sleep.

Su Zhe sat there comforting Su Yao for a long time, but Su Yao just kept crying and asking him, "Brother, where is my daughter? My Zhuzi, where is she now? Have her grandparents returned her? Can you go ask them for her back?"

After saying that, she got out of bed barefoot and wanted to go to the Sheng family. No matter how many people tried to hold her back, they couldn't stop her.

It wasn't until the doctor gave her a sedative injection that she finally fell into a deep sleep.

Sheng Yu was so frightened that she cried loudly and didn't even go to kindergarten in the morning.

The situation was getting more and more serious.

No one had expected that Su Yao would become like this within just two days after seeing Xu Qingzhu only once and hearing the two characters "Qingzhu."

Given time, she would definitely remember.

But once she remembered that she had a daughter, she would inevitably recall those painful memories.

The scene of Sheng Qinglin's death would replay over and over in her mind, and the scene of her daughter being taken away would also be remembered repeatedly. Under such circumstances, asking Su Yao to reconcile with the Sheng family was simply a pipe dream.

Even Su Zhe couldn't do it.

To him, the Sheng family were mortal enemies—enemies for life!

So he wanted Xu Qingzhu to choose one or the other, and the outcome was even predetermined—she could only choose the Su family. After all, this was her biological mother, her biological mother who had suffered so much!

But after hearing everything, Xu Qingzhu was silent for a moment, then still said firmly, "My answer is still the same. I want both."

Su Zhe looked at her. "Why are you so stubbornly obstinate!"

"Is wanting both a father and a mother being stubbornly obstinate?" Xu Qingzhu spoke at a slow, even pace. She didn't deliberately oppose him, but simply stated her viewpoint calmly. That cool, clear voice rang out in the private room. "If you want to put it that way, then consider me stubbornly obstinate. Even children of divorced parents can visit both separately. I don't want to choose only one."

Xu Qingzhu said, "I can accept that my father has passed away, that my mother has gone mad or become foolish. But I cannot accept that by choosing my father, I cannot choose my mother."

Su Zhe stared at her blankly. In that instant, it was as if he saw the cheerful and radiant Su Yao from over twenty years ago.

Especially the way she firmly stated her position—it was so much like how Su Yao looked when she stood on the podium giving her acceptance speech.

Resolute and steady.

"To me, they're both people who gave birth to me but never raised me." Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly. "So either I acknowledge both, or I acknowledge neither."